

Hawthorne Effect

What is it?

People change their behavior when they know they are being observed. Knowing someone is watching makes them act better, more careful, or more intentional than normal.

History

This originated from research at the Hawthorne Works factory in the 1920s. Researchers noticed that workers improved productivity not because of actual changes, but simply because they were aware they were part of an experiment.

The Psychology Behind It

- Awareness of being observed increases performance temporarily
- People want to look better in front of evaluators
- Feedback becomes distorted because behavior is not natural
- Data collected in this state does not reflect real world usage

Why It Matters

- Misleading test results
- Skewed research insights
- Wrong product decisions

How to Apply It

- Reduce observer presence
- Build trust during user studies
- Use multiple research methods
- Run long-term studies to capture real behavior

Theory in Action

- Retail brands use mystery shoppers to evaluate staff without altering behavior
- Users tend to act differently in moderated research sessions vs natural environments

Final Thought

People behave differently when they know they are being watched. Understanding this helps designers collect more accurate insights and avoid false validation.

